

M5T4: Personal Care Product Audit — 9 min

Video File M5T4-PersonalCare.mp4 (product label breakdowns; safe examples) · **Resources** Safe Product Guide.pdf (30-second label check, ingredient watch-list, audit sheet, DIY scrub, skin-change tracker) · **Xp** 70 total · Audit & Swap 2 Products 40 · Track Skin Changes 30

Target runtime 9 min · 1,132 spoken words · ≈ 7.5 min at 150 wpm · ≈ 8.4 min at a warm 135 wpm

0:00–0:30 HOOK

[VISUAL: Cynthia at her bathroom counter, ten products lined up. She turns one over and points to a single word: "fragrance."]

Count the products you put on your body before nine a.m. Most people get to eight or ten before they've left the house: shampoo, conditioner, body wash, lotion, deodorant, sunscreen, something for the face, something for the lips. Each one has an ingredient list, and on most of them there's one word doing a lot of hiding. Today we learn to read that list in thirty seconds, and to swap the two products that matter most.

0:30–3:30 THE RISKS, PRECISELY

[VISUAL: Slide: "Parabens · Phthalates · 'Fragrance.'"]

Three names. Parabens are preservatives, common in lotions, shampoos, and cosmetics, and they're weakly estrogenic. A study from the Harvard fertility cohort published in Environmental Health Perspectives found that men with

higher urinary paraben levels had more sperm DNA damage, and a companion study in the same journal linked paraben exposure in women to markers of diminished ovarian reserve. Phthalates make products cling and fragrances last; John Meeker's and Russ Hauser's work, in *Epidemiology* and in *Environmental Health Perspectives*, has linked phthalate metabolites to poorer semen quality in men and, in a 2016 study, to lower egg yields and pregnancy rates in women going through IVF.

[VISUAL: Slide: "The word 'fragrance' can legally contain dozens of undisclosed ingredients."]

And "fragrance," or "parfum." In most countries, that single word can stand for a proprietary mixture of dozens of chemicals that don't have to be listed, and phthalates are frequently among them. So the simplest and most effective rule in this whole training is: fragrance-free. Not "unscented," which can mean a masking fragrance was added. Fragrance-free.

[VISUAL: Slide: "How much gets through the skin? It depends on the chemical."]

You'll hear that the skin absorbs sixty percent of what you put on it. That figure isn't from the research, and I'd rather give you what is. Skin absorption varies enormously by chemical;

some pass through hardly at all, others readily. What we know for the ones we care about comes from studies like one in Environmental Science and Technology, where Janjua and colleagues applied a cream containing parabens and a phthalate to volunteers' skin and measured the chemicals in their urine within hours. They got in. That's enough to act on. And remember that lotion is on your skin all day, every day, so even modest absorption adds up.

There's also what you breathe. Sprays, perfumes, and scented lotions release fragrance compounds into the air of a small, steamy bathroom, and you inhale them. Nail products and hair sprays are the strongest offenders. So the bathroom, like the kitchen, benefits from ventilation, and it benefits from fewer aerosols altogether. Roll-on rather than spray, cream rather than mist, and a window open while you get ready.

3:30–6:30 THE AUDIT

[VISUAL: Product label breakdown: an ingredient list on screen with the watch-list words highlighted.]

Here's the thirty-second label check. Turn the product over. Scan for four things. One: "fragrance" or "parfum." Two: any word ending in "-paraben," methylparaben, propylparaben, butylparaben. Three: "DEP," "DBP," or "phthalate," which are

rarely listed but sometimes are. Four: the length of the list; a shorter list is usually a safer list. If it fails on one or two, it's a candidate for swapping. That's the audit, and the Safe Product Guide has a sheet to record each product's score.

[VISUAL: Slide: "EWG Skin Deep and similar databases: a starting point, not gospel."]

For a deeper look, the Environmental Working Group's Skin Deep database rates thousands of products by ingredient. It's a useful starting point with a caveat: its scoring is conservative and some ratings are debated, so use it to compare options rather than to panic. Some countries' consumer bodies run similar tools. A product that scores well in one of these, is fragrance-free, and has a short list is a good product.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Prioritize: what's on the most skin for the longest."]

Prioritize by contact. Body lotion and deodorant sit on a lot of skin for a long time; swap those first. Then the daily shampoo and body wash. Sunscreen: keep wearing it, choose a mineral one, zinc oxide or titanium dioxide, which sit on the skin rather than in it. Makeup and perfume: perfume is nearly pure fragrance, so it's a high-impact swap if you wear it daily; makeup matters less by volume, but a fragrance-free foundation is easy to find. Partners: men's products are just as

fragranced, often more; aftershave, body spray, and hair product deserve the same audit.

One category people ask about constantly is hair dye and nail salons. The research on hair dye and fertility is limited and mostly reassuring for occasional use; if you color your hair, choose a well-ventilated salon, avoid it in the first trimester once you're pregnant, and consider ammonia-free options. Nail salons expose workers far more than customers; if you go, pick one with good ventilation and skip the gel curing if you can. These are lower priorities than your daily lotion, and I'd rather you swapped the lotion than gave up the things that make you feel like yourself.

6:30–8:00 **ALTERNATIVES AND DIY**

[VISUAL: Safe examples: generic fragrance-free lotion, plain castile soap, a mineral sunscreen, a simple deodorant with a short list. No brand endorsement.]

Alternatives don't need to be expensive or exotic. Fragrance-free lines exist in every price range, often in the sensitive-skin section. Plain castile soap does hair and body for many people. A mineral sunscreen. A deodorant with a short list, and a warning: switching deodorants sometimes takes two weeks for the skin to settle, so change it before an important

event, not the morning of. Coconut oil or plain shea butter as body lotion, if your skin likes them.

[DEMO: Cynthia mixes a body scrub in a small jar: sugar, olive oil, a squeeze of lemon.]

And one thing you can make: a body scrub. Half a cup of sugar, a quarter cup of olive or almond oil, and a squeeze of lemon or a few drops of vanilla if you want a scent you can trust. Stir, jar, use in the shower once or twice a week. It costs pennies, it exfoliates, it moisturizes, and there is no ingredient list to read. That's the whole point of DIY here: not that homemade is magical, but that you know exactly what's in it.

Two cautions with DIY, because the internet has some bad ideas. Don't put essential oils on your skin undiluted or use them as a "natural" substitute for everything; many are strong sensitizers, some affect hormones in the lab, and quality varies wildly. And don't make your own sunscreen; homemade sunscreens don't provide reliable protection, and sunburn is a far bigger risk than the ingredients in a mineral SPF. Keep DIY to the simple things: scrubs, an oil for moisture, a castile soap. Buy the rest, fragrance-free, with a short list.

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera.]

Choose clean for a radiant conception prep, not because your body is fragile, but because it's precious, and because the small daily doses are the ones that add up over the ninety days we're preparing. Track your skin for a few weeks after the swaps; many people notice less irritation, which is a nice reminder that what's good for your fertility is often good for the rest of you.

[VISUAL: End card: "Safe Product Guide PDF → Audit and swap 2 products (40 XP) → Track skin changes (30 XP)."]

Download the Safe Product Guide, audit your products and swap the two highest-contact ones for forty XP, and track your skin for two weeks for thirty. Next, Training Five: gentle protocols, honest science, and a warning I'd like every man in this course to hear.

ACTION CALLOUT

RESOURCE Safe Product Guide.pdf (30-second label check, ingredient watch-list, audit sheet, priority order, safe alternatives by category, DIY scrub, 14-day skin tracker).

ACTION 1: Audit your products and swap the two with the most skin contact (40 XP).

ACTION 2: Track skin changes for 14 days (30 XP). **NEXT STEP:** Training 5 · Gentle Detox Protocols.